Mahatma Gandhi University, Kottayam

Third Semester |Discipline Specific Core Course

Foundations of Sociological Thought (MG3DSCSOC200)

Part A: Very Short Answers (2marks)

1. Herbert Spencer applied Darwin's theory of evolution to society, explaining progress through adaptation. His ideas formed the basis of social evolutionism and differentiation. [U] / [CO1]
2. Structural- functionalism sees society as a structure of interrelated parts functioning to maintain equilibrium and stability among social institutions. [U] / [CO1]
3. 'Survival of the fittest' means that only adaptable individuals or societies progress, linking biological evolution with social development. [U] / [CO2)
4. [U] / [CO2] Industrial society is characterized by voluntary cooperation, specialization of labour, and contract-based relationships replacing status-based ties.
5. [E] / [CO3] Economy determines all life aspects because material conditions influence ideas, politics, and culture, as argued by Marx in historical materialism.
6. [U] / [CO3] Dialectics stresses contradictions and social change, while metaphysics focuses on static, abstract reasoning detached from material reality.
7. [K] / [CO3] Durkheim defines 'social facts' as external, coercive norms that exist independently and constrain individual actions.
8. [K] / [CO3] Durkheim's four types of suicide are egoistic, altruistic, anomic, and fatalistic—each linked to varying social integration levels.
9. [E] / [CO3] Ideal types provide conceptual clarity for comparison, but they are subjective and lack empirical accuracy.
10. [U] / [CO3] Totemism, according to Durkheim, represents the worship of social symbols that embody collective consciousness.
11. [An] / [CO1] Functionalism emphasizes order and consensus; conflict theory highlights power struggles and social inequality.
12. [An] / [CO2] Military societies rely on compulsion and hierarchy, whereas industrial societies encourage cooperation and freedom.
13. [A] / [CO4] Symbolic Interactionism is a micro theory that studies how individuals construct meanings through social interactions.

14. [A] / [CO3] Historical materialism illustrates that economic transformations, like the Industrial Revolution, reshape social relations and class structures.
15. [K] / [CO2] A super-organism refers to society functioning as an organism, with interdependent structures maintaining social order.
16. [K] / [CO3] Social solidarity denotes unity achieved through shared norms, values, and social integration among members.

Part B: Short Essays (Six Marks)

17a. The four major theoretical perspectives in sociology are: **Functionalism** – society as a system of interrelated parts maintaining stability. **Conflict Theory** – focuses on inequality and power struggles. **Symbolic Interactionism** – studies individual interactions and meanings. **Feminist Perspective** – examines gender inequalities in social institutions. **[K] / [CO1]. OR**

17 b. Comte's **Positivism** is limited in modern sociology as it overemphasizes scientific objectivity, neglects subjective meanings, and fails to address social change and diversity. It reduces human behavior to empirical observation, ignoring interpretive and critical dimensions of society.
[An] / [CO2)

18a. Durkheim's **Division of Labour** highlights social solidarity and interdependence in modern societies. Its strength lies in explaining social cohesion through specialization, but it is criticized for ignoring workplace inequalities, exploitation, and the alienation found in modern organizations.
[U] / [CO3] OR

18b. Karl Marx was a German philosopher and economist. His central contribution was the **Conflict Theory**, explaining how economic structures (base) shape social relations (superstructure) and emphasizing class struggle as the driver of historical change.
[K] / [CO3]

19a. The **Theological Stage**, according to Comte, explains phenomena through supernatural or divine forces. For example, ancient people attributed thunder to the anger of gods. It represents the earliest stage in human intellectual development.
[K] / [CO2] OR

19b. The **Religion of Humanity**, proposed by Comte, replaces worship of God with reverence for humankind. It promotes moral order, altruism, and unity by encouraging people to serve society selflessly.
[U] / [CO2]

20a. The **criticisms of social action theory** include its overemphasis on individual agency, neglect of structural factors, and difficulty in empirical testing. It may also

overlook collective or institutional influences on behaviour.
[An] / [CO3] OR

20b. The **Hierarchy of Sciences** by Comte arranges sciences from simple to complex: Mathematics → Astronomy → Physics → Chemistry → Biology → Sociology. It reflects his belief that sociology is the "queen of sciences," integrating all others to study society.
[A] / [CO2]